

“Ratings,” then “Insurance,” and then, at last, you can click on the “Credit Ratings List.”

As you do your research, it’s essential to know what each rating means. For example, a company that gets a “B” from Moody’s is considered to be “weak.” Consult each company’s ratings definitions to make sure you’re interpreting them correctly.

- **If you use an agent, ask about qualifications.** When you’re buying life, health, or disability insurance, look for an agent who has the letters “CLU” after his or her name. This stands for Chartered Life Underwriter. If you’re looking for car, homeowners, or renters coverage, the designation to look for is “CPCU” (Chartered Property Casualty Underwriter). Although these credentials offer no guarantee that you’ll get good service, they do tell you that the agent has taken tough insurance courses and has a certain amount of basic knowledge. For a list of individuals with a CLU, try the Society of Financial Service Professionals (www.financialpro.org/consumer/find.cfm). To verify that an agent is a CPCU, go to www.aicpcu.org/about.htm, then click on “Search for a Certificate/Designation Holder.”
- **Run a check with your state insurance department.** Figure 8–1 lists the websites and phone numbers of every state insurance department. Send an email or call to make sure the agent you’re dealing with is licensed in your state. Some state insurance departments will tell you whether there have been any complaints filed against an agent. You can also call to see if there have been any complaints filed against the insurance company you’re considering.

↓ **MAKING THE MOST OF YOUR EMPLOYER’S PLANS**

If you work for a big company, your employer might be paying for the bulk of your health insurance premiums and may supply you with a fixed amount of life and disability insurance. The type and amount of insurance